

Gascon was to inclose his treasure, for the present, under locks so solid that no wrist could break them, and so complicated that no master-key could open them. D'Artagnan remembered that the English are masters in mechanics and conservative industry; and he determined to go in the morning in search of a mechanic who would sell him a strong box. He did not go far; Master Will Jobson, dwelling in Piccadilly, listened to his propositions, comprehended his wishes, and promised to make him a safety lock that should relieve him from all future fear.

'I will give you,' said he, 'a piece of mechanism entirely new. At the first serious attempt upon your lock, an invisible plate will open of itself and vomit forth a pretty copper bullet the weight of a mark—which will knock down the intruder, and not with a loud report. What do you think of it?'

'I think it very ingenious,' cried D'Artagnan; 'the little copper bullet pleases me mightily. So now, sir mechanic, the terms?'

'A fortnight for the execution, and fifteen hundred livres payable on delivery,' replied the artisan.

D'Artagnan's brow darkened. A fortnight was delay enough to allow the thieves of London time to remove all occasion for the strong box. As to the fifteen hundred livres—that would be paying too dear for what a little vigilance would procure him for nothing.

'I will think of it,' said he; 'thank you, sir.' And he returned home at full speed; nobody had yet touched his treasure. That same day Athos paid a visit to his friend and found him so thoughtful that he could not help expressing his surprise.

'How is this?' said he, 'you are rich and not gay—you, who were so anxious for wealth!'

'My friend, the pleasures to which we are not accustomed oppress us more than the griefs with which we are familiar. Give me your opinion, if you please. I can ask you, who have always had money: when we have money, what do we do with it?'

'That depends.'

'What have you done with yours, seeing that it has not made you a miser or a prodigal? For avarice dries up the heart, and prodigality drowns it—is that not so?'

'Fabricius could not have spoken more justly. But in truth, my money has never been a burden to me.'

'How so? Do you place it out at interest?'

'No; you know I have a tolerably handsome house, and that house composes the better part of my property.'

'I know it does.'

'So that you can be as rich as I am, and, indeed, more rich, whenever you like, by the same means.'

'But your rents,—do you lay them by?'

'No.'

'What do you think of a chest concealed in a wall?'

'I never made use of such a thing.'

'Then you must have some confidant, some safe man of business who pays you interest at a fair rate.'

'Not at all.'

'Good heavens! what do you do with it, then?'

'I spend all I have, and I only have what I spend, my dear D'Artagnan.'

'Ah! that may be. But you are something of a prince; fifteen or sixteen thousand livres melt away between your fingers; and then you have expenses and appearances—'

'Well, I don't see why you should be less of a noble than I am, my friend; your money would be quite sufficient.'

'Three hundred thousand livres! Two-thirds too much!'

'I beg your pardon—did you not tell me?—I thought I heard you say—I fancied you had a partner—'

'Ah! *Mordieu*! that's true,' cried D'Artagnan, colouring; 'there is Planchet. I had forgotten Planchet, upon my life! Well! there are my three hundred thousand livres broken into. That's a pity! it was a round sum, and sounded well. That is true, Athos; I am no longer rich. What a memory you have!'

'Tolerably good; yes, thank God!'

'The worthy Planchet!' grumbled D'Artagnan; 'his was not a bad dream! What a speculation! *Peste*! Well! what is said is said.'

'How much are you to give him?'

‘Oh!’ said D’Artagnan, ‘he is not a bad fellow; I shall arrange matters with him. I have had a great deal of trouble, you see, and expenses; all that must be taken into account.’

‘My dear friend, I can depend on you, and have no fear for the worthy Planchet; his interests are better in your hands than in his own. But now that you have nothing more to do here, we shall depart, if you please. You can go and thank his majesty, ask if he has any commands, and in six days we may be able to get sight of the towers of Notre Dame.’

‘My friend, I am most anxious to be off, and will go at once and pay my respects to the king.’

‘I,’ said Athos, ‘am going to call upon some friends in the city, and shall then be at your service.’

‘Will you lend me Grimaud?’

‘With all my heart. What do you want to do with him?’

‘Something very simple, and which will not fatigue him; I shall only beg him to take charge of my pistols, which lie there on the table near that coffer.’

‘Very well!’ replied Athos, imperturbably.

‘And he will not stir, will he?’

‘Not more than the pistols themselves.’

‘Then I shall go and take leave of his majesty. Au revoir!’

D’Artagnan arrived at St James’s, where Charles II, who was busy writing, kept him in the ante-chamber a full hour. Whilst walking about in the gallery, from the door to the window, from the window to the door, he thought he saw a cloak like Athos’s cross the vestibule; but at the moment he was going to ascertain if it were he, the usher summoned him to his majesty’s presence. Charles II rubbed his hands while receiving the thanks of our friend.

‘Chevalier,’ said he, ‘you are wrong to express gratitude to me; I have not paid you a quarter of the value of the history of the box into which you put the brave general—the excellent Duke of Albemarle, I mean.’ And the king laughed heartily.

D’Artagnan did not think it proper to interrupt his majesty, and he bowed with much modesty.

‘À propos,’ continued Charles, ‘do you think my dear Monk has really pardoned you?’

‘Pardoned me! yes, I hope so, sire!’

Chapter XXXIV

Of the Embarrassment of Riches



D’ARTAGNAN lost no time, and as soon as the thing was suitable and opportune, he paid a visit to the lord treasurer of his majesty. He had then the satisfaction to exchange a piece of paper, covered with very ugly writing, for a prodigious number of crowns, recently stamped with the effigies of his very gracious majesty Charles II.

D’Artagnan easily controlled himself: and yet, on this occasion, he could not help evincing a joy which the reader will perhaps comprehend, if he deigns to have some indulgence for a man who, since his birth, had never seen so many pieces and rolls of pieces juxta-placed in an order truly agreeable to the eye. The treasurer placed all the rolls in bags, and closed each bag with a stamp sealed with the arms of England, a favour which treasurers do not grant to everybody. Then, impassible, and just as polite as he ought to be towards a man honoured with the friendship of the king, he said to D’Artagnan:

‘Take away your money, sir.’ Your money! These words made a thousand chords vibrate in the heart of D’Artagnan, which he had never felt before. He had the bags packed in a small cart, and returned home meditating deeply. A man who possessed three hundred thousand livres can no longer expect to wear a smooth brow; a wrinkle for every hundred thousand livres is not too much.

D’Artagnan shut himself up, ate no dinner, closed his door to everybody, and, with a lighted lamp, and a loaded pistol on the table, he watched all night, ruminating upon the means of preventing these lovely crowns, which from the coffers of the king had passed into his coffers, from passing from his coffers into the pockets of any thief whatever. The best means discovered by the

'Adieu! gentlemen,' said Charles, holding out each of his hands to the two Frenchmen, who carried them to their lips.

'Well,' said Athos, when they were out of the palace, 'are you satisfied?'

'Hush!' said D'Artagnan, wild with joy, 'I have not yet returned from the treasurer's—a shutter may fall upon my head.'

'Eh!—but it was a cruel trick! Odds fish! to pack up the first personage of the English revolution like a herring. In your place I would not trust him, chevalier.'

'But, sire—'

'Yes, I know very well Monk calls you his friend, but he has too penetrating an eye not to have a memory, and too lofty a brow not to be very proud, you know, *grande supériorité*.'

'I shall certainly learn Latin,' said D'Artagnan to himself.

'But stop,' cried the merry monarch, 'I must manage your reconciliation; I know how to set about it; so—'

D'Artagnan bit his moustache. 'Will your majesty permit me to tell you the truth?'

'Speak, chevalier, speak.'

'Well, sire, you alarm me greatly. If your majesty undertakes the affair, as you seem inclined to do, I am a lost man; the duke will have me assassinated.'

The king burst into a fresh roar of laughter, which changed D'Artagnan's alarm into downright terror.

'Sire, I beg you to allow me to settle this matter myself, and if your majesty has no further need of my services—'

'No, chevalier. What, do you want to leave us?' replied Charles, with a hilarity that grew more and more alarming.

'If your majesty has no more commands for me.'

Charles became more serious.

'One single thing. See my sister, the Lady Henrietta. Do you know her?'

'No, sire, but—an old soldier like me is not an agreeable spectacle for a young and gay princess.'

'Ah! but my sister must know you; she must in case of need have you to depend upon.'

'Sire, every one that is dear to your majesty will be sacred to me.'

'Very well!—Parry! Come here, Parry!'

The side door opened and Parry entered, his face beaming with pleasure as soon as he saw D'Artagnan.

'What is Rochester doing?' said the king.

'He is on the canal with the ladies,' replied Parry.

'And Buckingham?'

'He is there also.'

'That is well. You will conduct the chevalier to Villiers; that is the Duke of Buckingham, chevalier; and beg the duke to introduce M. d'Artagnan to the Princess Henrietta.'

Parry bowed and smiled to D'Artagnan.

'Chevalier,' continued the king, 'this is your parting audience; you can afterwards set out as soon as you please.'

'Sire, I thank you.'

'But be sure you make your peace with Monk!'

'Oh, sire—'

'You know there is one of my vessels at your disposal?'

'Sire, you overpower me; I cannot think of putting your majesty's officers to inconvenience on my account.'

The king slapped D'Artagnan upon the shoulder.

'Nobody will be inconvenienced on your account, chevalier, but for that of an ambassador I am about sending to France, and to whom you will willingly serve as a companion, I fancy, for you know him.'

D'Artagnan appeared astonished.

'He is a certain Comte de la Fère,—whom you call Athos,' added the king; terminating the conversation, as he had begun it, by a joyous burst of laughter. 'Adieu, chevalier, adieu. Love me as I love you.' And thereupon, making a sign to Parry to ask if there were any one waiting for him in the adjoining closet, the king disappeared into that closet, leaving the chevalier perfectly astonished by this singular audience. The old man took his arm in a friendly way, and led him towards the garden.



TAKing IT BY THE POINT HE PRESENTED IT TO THE KING

paid; for there is nothing in the world but the general's sword which is worth as much as himself.'

'Odds fish! as my father said,' cried Charles. 'That is a gallant proposal, and a gallant man, is he not, duke?'

'Upon my honour, yes, sire,' and he drew his sword. 'Monsieur,' said he to D'Artagnan, 'here is what you demand. Many have handled a better blade; but however modest mine may be, I have never surrendered it to any one.'

D'Artagnan received with pride the sword which had just made a king.

'Oh! oh!' cried Charles II; 'what a sword that has restored me to my throne—to go out of the kingdom—and not, one day, to figure among the crown jewels! No, on my soul! that shall not be! Captain d'Artagnan, I will give you two hundred thousand livres for your sword! If that is too little, say so.'

'It is too little, sire,' replied D'Artagnan, with inimitable seriousness. 'In the first place, I do not at all wish to sell it; but your majesty desires me to do so, and that is an order. I obey, then, but the respect I owe to the illustrious warrior who hears me, commands me to estimate a third more the reward of my victory. I ask then three hundred thousand livres for the sword, or I shall give it to your majesty for nothing.' And taking it by the point he presented it to the king. Charles broke into hilarious laughter.

'A gallant man, and a merry companion! Odds fish! is he not, duke? is he not, comte? He pleases me! I like him! Here, Chevalier d'Artagnan, take this.' And going to the table, he took a pen and wrote an order upon his treasurer for three hundred thousand livres.

D'Artagnan took it, and turning gravely towards Monk: 'I have still asked too little, I know,' said he, 'but believe me, your grace, I would rather have died that allow myself to be governed by avarice.'

The king began to laugh again, like the happiest cockney of his kingdom.

'You will come and see me again before you go, chevalier?' said he; 'I shall want to play in a stock of gayety now my Frenchmen are leaving me.'

'Ah! sire, it will not be with the gayety as with the duke's sword; I will give it to your majesty gratis,' replied D'Artagnan, whose feet scarcely seemed to touch the ground.

'And you, comte,' added Charles, turning towards Athos, 'come again, also; I have an important message to confide to you. Your hand, duke.' Monk pressed the hand of the king.

Chapter XXXV

On the Canal



UPON the green waters of the canal bordered with marble, upon which time had already scattered black spots and tufts of mossy grass, there glided majestically a long, flat bark adorned with the arms of England, surmounted by a dais, and carpeted with long damasked stuffs, which trailed their fringes in the water.

Eight rowers, leaning lazily to their oars, made it move upon the canal with the graceful slowness of the swans, which, disturbed in their ancient possessions by the approach of the bark, looked from a distance at this splendid and noisy pageant. We say noisy—for the bark contained four guitar and lute players, two singers, and several courtiers, all sparkling with gold and precious stones, and showing their white teeth in emulation of each other, to please the Lady Henrietta Stuart, grand-daughter of Henry IV, daughter of Charles I, and sister of Charles II, who occupied the seat of honour under the dais of the bark. We know this young princess, we have seen her at the Louvre with her mother, wanting wood, wanting bread, and fed by the coadjuteur and the parliament. She had, therefore, like her brothers, passed through an uneasy youth; then, all at once, she had just awakened from a long and horrible dream, seated on the steps of a throne, surrounded by courtiers and flatterers. Like Mary Stuart on leaving prison, she aspired not only to life and liberty, but to power and wealth.

The Lady Henrietta, in growing, had attained remarkable beauty, which the recent restoration had rendered celebrated. Misfortune had taken from her the lustre of pride, but prosperity had restored it to her. She was resplendent, then, in her joy and her happiness,—like those hot-house flowers which, forgotten during a frosty autumn night, have hung their heads, but which on the morrow,

warned once more by the atmosphere in which they were born, rise again with greater splendour than ever. Villiers, Duke of Buckingham, son of him who played so conspicuous a part in the early chapters of this history,—Villiers of Buckingham, a handsome cavalier, melancholy with women, a jester with men,—and Wilmot, Lord Rochester, a jester with both sexes, were standing at this moment before the Lady Henrietta, disputing the privilege of making her smile. As to that young and beautiful princess, reclining upon a cushion of velvet bordered with gold, her hands hanging listlessly so as to dip in the water, she listened carelessly to the musicians without hearing them, and heard the two courtiers without appearing to listen to them.

This Lady Henrietta—this charming creature—this woman who joined the graces of France to the beauties of England, not having yet loved, was cruel in her coquetry. The smile, then,—that innocent favour of young girls,—did not even lighten her countenance; and if, at times, she did raise her eyes, it was to fasten them upon one or other of the cavaliers with such a fixity, that their gallantry, bold as it generally was, took the alarm, and became timid.

In the meanwhile the boat continued its course, the musicians made a great noise, and the courtiers began, like them, to be out of breath. Besides, the excursion became doubtless monotonous to the princess, for all at once, shaking her head with an air of impatience,—‘Come gentlemen,—enough of this,—let us land.’

‘Ah, madam,’ said Buckingham, ‘we are very unfortunate! We have not succeeded in making the excursion agreeable to your royal highness.’

‘My mother expects me,’ replied the princess; ‘and I must frankly admit, gentlemen, I am bored.’ And whilst uttering this cruel word, Henrietta endeavoured to console by a look each of the two young men, who appeared terrified at such frankness. The look produced its effect—the two faces brightened; but immediately, as if the royal coquette thought she had done too much for simple mortals, she made a movement, turned her back on both her adorers, and appeared plunged in a reverie in which it was evident they had no part.

Buckingham bit his lips with anger, for he was truly in love with the Lady Henrietta, and, in that case, took everything in a serious light. Rochester bit his lips likewise, but his wit always dominated over his heart, it was purely and simply to repress a malicious smile. The princess was then allowing the eyes

sorrowful and so comically piteous, that the king, who caught it, could not restrain a smile. Monk was preparing to leave the room, to take leave of Charles. ‘What! my trusty and well-beloved!’ said the king to the duke, ‘are you going?’

‘With your majesty’s permission, for in truth I am weary. The emotions of the day have worn me out; I stand in need of rest.’

‘But,’ said the king, ‘you are not going without M. d’Arragnan, I hope.’

‘Why not, sire?’ said the old warrior.

‘Well! you know very well why,’ said the king.

Monk looked at Charles with astonishment.

‘Oh! it may be possible; but if you forget, you, M. d’Arragnan, do not.’

Astonishment was painted on the face of the musketeer.

‘Well, then, duke,’ said the king, ‘do you not lodge with M. d’Arragnan?’

‘I had the honour of offering M. d’Arragnan a lodging; yes, sire.’

‘That idea is your own, and yours solely?’

‘Mine and mine only; yes, sire.’

‘Well! but it could not be otherwise—the prisoner always lodges with his conqueror.’

Monk coloured in his turn. ‘Ah! that is true,’ said he; ‘I am M. d’Arragnan’s prisoner.’

‘Without doubt, duke, since you are not yet ransomed; but have no care of that; it was I who took you out of M. d’Arragnan’s hands, and it is I who will pay your ransom.’

The eyes of D’Arragnan regained their gaiety and their brilliancy. The Gascon began to understand. Charles advanced towards him.

‘The general,’ said he, ‘is not rich, and cannot pay you what he is worth. I am richer, certainly; but now that he is a duke, and if not a king, almost a king, he is worth a sum I could not perhaps pay. Come, M. d’Arragnan, be moderate with me; how much do I owe you?’

D’Arragnan, delighted at the turn things were taking, but not for a moment losing his self-possession, replied,—‘Sire, your majesty has no occasion to be alarmed. When I had the good fortune to take his grace, M. Monk was only a general; it is therefore only a general’s ransom that is due to me. But if the general will have the kindness to deliver me his sword, I shall consider myself